

LIFE-STUDY OF EPHESIANS
MESSAGE FORTY-ONE
THE WAY TO BE PERFECTED

In 4:12 Paul speaks of the “perfecting of the saints unto the work of ministry, unto the building up of the Body of Christ.” In this message we shall consider the way to be perfected.

GRACE ACCORDING TO THE MEASURE OF THE GIFT OF CHRIST

Ephesians 4:7 says, “But to each one of us was given grace according to the measure of the gift of Christ.” Notice that in this verse Paul does not say, “to each one of you”; he says, “to each one of us.” This indicates that Paul was including himself. He did not put himself in a special category, in a category separate from that of the other saints.

Grace has been given to each of us according to the measure of the gift of Christ. Each member of our physical body has a certain measure. For example, the measure of the ear is of one size, and the measure of the shoulder is of another. The words “the measure of the gift of Christ” refer to the size of a member of Christ’s Body. With every member there is a certain size, a certain measure. Just as our blood supplies the members of our body according to their size, grace also is given to each member according to its size. Although there is more blood in the shoulder than in the ear, the quality of the blood is the same. Just as blood is the life supply to our physical body, so grace is the life supply to the members in the Body of Christ. Praise the Lord that all the saints are gifts of Christ to whom grace has been given! [346]

THE WORK OF MINISTRY

Since verses 9 and 10 are parenthetical, verse 11 is the continuation of verse 8. Verse 11 says, “And He gave some apostles, and some prophets, and some evangelists, and some shepherds and teachers.” As verse 12 makes clear, these have been given for the “perfecting of the saints unto the work of ministry, unto the building up of the Body of Christ.” According to grammar, the phrase “unto the building up of the Body of Christ” is in apposition to the phrase “unto the work of ministry.” This indicates that both phrases refer to the same thing. Hence, the work of ministry is the building up of the Body.

The apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers perfect the saints unto the work of ministry. Whose work is this—the work of the gifted ones mentioned in verse 11, or the work of the saints? Is it the work of the perfecting ones, or the work of the perfected ones? The answer is that it is the work both of the perfecting ones and the perfected ones. The building up of the Body is not only the work of the apostles and the other gifted ones, but also the work of all the saints. I believe that the work of ministry in verse 12 refers more to the work of the saints than it does to the work of the apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers.

The work of building the meeting hall in Anaheim is an illustration of this. Many brothers worked on the construction of the hall. But very few of these brothers were professional builders. Most of them had little experience in the building trades. The few experienced tradesmen took the lead, and gradually the inexperienced ones were perfected. Eventually, both the journeymen and the learners worked together on the building of the meeting hall. However, most of the work was done, not by the professionals, but by the learners. In the same principle, the work of ministry refers to the unique work of building up the Body of Christ. This work is the responsibility not mainly of the apostles, but of all the saints. Both the leading apostles and [347] prophets and all the believers, including even the smallest member, work together to build up the Body.

THE CONCEPT OF HIERARCHY

At this point I need to say a frank and honest word about the degraded condition of today's Christianity. Christianity has become degraded largely because of the influence of the natural concept. According to the natural concept, in any group or society there should be ranks among the people, with some of a higher rank and others of a lower rank. Ignatius, one of the great church fathers, a good teacher and a pious man, made the mistake of saying that bishops are higher than elders. He said that the authority of the elders is local, but that the authority of the bishops is regional. Through such a concept the seed of hierarchy was sown. As the hierarchy developed, there were not only bishops, but also archbishops, cardinals, and, at the top, the pope. After the Reformation, this hierarchy was not abolished. Rather, it continued in various forms in the Protestant denominations, and it still exists today.

The concept of a hierarchy or a pyramid arrangement among the believers, fits into the natural concept. But if we have the light from the clear revelation in the New Testament, we shall see that the church is not a pyramid; it is a living organism, the Body, with Christ as the unique Head. In Matthew 23:8-10 the Lord Jesus said, "But you, do not be called Rabbi; for One is your Teacher, and you are all brothers. And do not call anyone your father on the earth; for One is your Father, He Who is in the heavens. Neither be called leaders, because One is your Leader, the Christ." Nevertheless, according to the natural concept, the twelve apostles are regarded as being above all the other saints. However, if you study the New Testament carefully, you will not find very much difference between the twelve apostles and all the other disciples. The grace in the New Testament is not given uniquely to the twelve apostles, but generally to all the disciples. In John 17 the Lord Jesus prayed, not for the apostles, but for the disciples. Furthermore, in chapter [348] twenty of John, the Lord appeared on the day of His resurrection to the disciples. On the day of Pentecost one hundred twenty were together praying. The Spirit poured out on the day of Pentecost was poured out upon all the disciples, not just upon the apostles.

NO RANK AMONG THE BELIEVERS

In the New Testament economy there is no thought of hierarchy. On the contrary, God's economy in the New Testament makes all the believers of the same rank. This is the reason that the Lord Jesus said that we all are brothers and that only Christ is our Leader, Guide, Instructor, and Director. Although God's economy puts all believers in Christ on the same level, the natural concept is that in the church, as in any social group or organization, there should be a special class of leaders.

THE APOSTOLIC AGE

Due to the influence of this concept, a great mistake was made in the history of the church. According to the traditional view of church history, the first century is regarded as the apostolic age. This concept is erroneous. The apostolic age includes the entire New Testament age. Is the present age not part of the apostolic age? If it is not, then what age is it—the age of the clergy or the age of the hierarchy? If we are enlightened by the revelation in the New Testament, we shall see that the whole New Testament age is the apostolic age.

Some have said that the apostolic age is over and that it is impossible to have apostles today. In his early ministry, Brother Nee was not yet entirely free from the influence of this concept. In *The Assembly Life*, a book published in 1934, Brother Nee said that there are no official elders, only "unofficial" elders. Furthermore, he said that there are no apostles today, but that there is a group of people who are doing the work of apostles, such as preaching the gospel and establishing churches. Brother Nee admitted that those who do the work of apostles today do not have the holiness, the [349] power, nor the victory of the apostles. Nevertheless, as Brother Nee remarked, God is using people to work for Him in every locality in a way similar to the way He used the apostles in the first century. In the past it was the apostles who established churches, but today it is those who are doing the work of the apostles who establish churches in various localities. Brother Nee pointed out that these ones are not worthy to be compared to the apostles nor even to be called apostles, but that they are

nonetheless doing part of the work of the apostles. These are the people God is using in the midst of the degraded situation of the church today. In that book published in 1934 Brother Nee realized that certain people were doing the work of apostles, but he did not dare to call them apostles. However, he called them “unofficial” apostles who appointed “unofficial” elders in the local assemblies.

Three years later, in 1937, Brother Nee saw from the New Testament that it is erroneous to say that the apostolic age is over and that there can be no apostles today. Therefore, he published the book entitled *The Normal Christian Church Life*, where he boldly said that there are still apostles today. When this book was published about forty years ago, we had seen only part of the light on this matter and on matters related to it. Now, in the light of chapters three and four of Ephesians, we see that all the saints can do the same kind of work as the early apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers did.

PERFECTING THE SAINTS

We have pointed out that the gifted persons in 4:11 are for the perfecting of the saints. What do you suppose the apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers perfect the saints to do? The only reasonable and logical answer is that they perfect them to do the same thing that they themselves do. For example, a mathematics teacher trains his students in mathematics. His goal is to teach them to do what he himself is able to do. Eventually, through years of training, his students will also be able to become teachers [350] of mathematics. But suppose a certain teacher has taught mathematics for many years without perfecting even one student. What a poor teacher he would be! Nevertheless, this is actually the situation that exists among many Christians today. Many Christians attend so-called church services year after year without being perfected in the least. About twenty-five years ago, some brothers from the church in Manila went to a hospital to visit a certain brother who was sick. As they gathered around the brother’s bed, each of them offered prayer to the Lord. Some other Christians were nearby and were greatly surprised to hear so many people praying. One of them said to our brothers, “In our church, the pastor is the only one who prays in a public way. We don’t know how to pray. But look at you—every one is able to pray. What kind of church do you go to?” This is just one example of the shortage of a perfecting work among today’s Christians.

I am very burdened about the situation among us in the Lord’s recovery. I must honestly ask myself how many brothers and sisters have been perfected under this ministry. Just as we can earn a college degree by four years of diligent study, so we should show some marks of being perfected after several years in the Lord’s recovery. But many have been with us for years, but they seem not to have been perfected very much. Because of this, certain aspects of the clergy-laity system have crept in among us. We cannot tolerate this. We are not here to have so-called services as in Christianity. What we do in the meetings must be for the perfecting of the saints. If we are faithful to perfect the brothers and sisters, then after three or four years everyone will be perfected to do the same kind of work as was done by the early apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers.

In Acts 8 a persecution rose up against the church, and the believers were forced to scatter. The apostles, however, remained in Jerusalem. The disciples who were scattered spontaneously did the work of apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers. Suppose today’s Christians [351] were scattered because of persecution. What would these scattered ones be able to do? We need to ask this question of ourselves. What would we be able to do if we were scattered? My hope is that many would be able to function as apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers. Finding themselves in an unfamiliar place, some would become burdened for the Lord’s interests there. Firstly, they would preach the gospel. Then they would care for those who are saved by shepherding them and teaching them. We all need to be perfected in order to do this work.